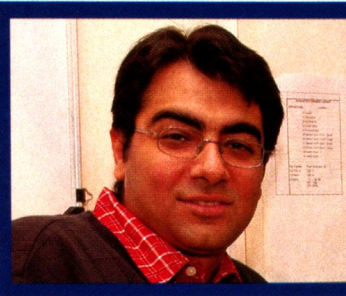


being used by people to connect with their college and school friends across the globe, the most popular groups on BigAdda or Desimartini are local in nature. From Nasik to Rourkela and Allahabad, every city has a separate presence on these sites. "People may visit different places but they connect best at home," says Amiy Roy, 38, marketing head, BigAdda, which currently boasts of more than two million registered users.

But figures don't always show the true picture, say Internet researchers. Most figures only indicate the number of registrations but fail to give the exact number of active users. While Facebook currently has over 3.5 lakh active Indian users, with the country ranking

**"We want to build a space where people get to know each other through a more meaningful interaction than just friendship."**

**PARAG CHORDIA & PRERNA GUPTA,**  
Founders, YAARI



**"Local content was lacking on the Internet. Users can now put up referrals for a servant or an electrician."**

**RAJESH MOORJANI,**  
Founder, ILAAKA

ninth on a list of 55 most active countries on the website, the same may not be true for desi sites that claim higher memberships. "People check their Facebook accounts regularly and compulsively. I am not sure if they do the same with their Indian accounts," says Siddharth Rao, 30, co-founder of interactive services company Web Chutney.

Raja Marthandan is a classic example. The 25-year-old Chennai-based corporate communications executive is registered on Orkut, Facebook, BigAdda, Minglebox and Yaari. But after two years of being on the social network circuit, he's learnt to be selective. Now, his only active accounts are Orkut and Facebook. His Indian accounts, sadly, are languishing in cyberspace. As Rao points out, "Unless they do something to differentiate themselves, I don't see them surviving."

It's something the site-owners have realised. Though they have been successful in tapping the local sentiments, they have failed to match the resources and technology. That is how ilaaka and Minglebox are trying to stand out. Both the sites are combining a number of interesting features,

providing local information being one of them. Started by software professional Rajesh Moorjani, 32, ilaaka's strong point is its

event and shopping listings, where people can know what's happening in their neighbourhood. Throw in recommendations for a good electrician, a domestic help or even an iPod dealer and you've got 50,000 active users on the website. Though Minglebox doesn't work on the value-adding model, the website has found another selling point—colleges. The site has a completely different section called campus where news about the latest goings-on from exams to festivals, is posted.

In their nascent stages, in order to survive, Indian social networking sites also have another roadblock—the question of making money. Unless a website starts raking in big bucks, it's going to be very difficult for them to survive, however novel the idea may be. Currently most Indian sites make money through Google AdSense or a few stray advertisements. Gupta says, "People have been sceptical of the success of online advertisement but we are all for it." The advertisements also, however, are directly proportionate to the users. If an advertiser or his peers do not use an Indian website, there is very little chance that he will buy space there. It is then only a matter of time before Indian social networking sites become another bubble that will burst. Or will it be a Web 2.0 success story that will become a reference point for future entrepreneurs? Only time will tell. Till then, happy Orkut-ing, nay Addabaa-zi. ■